

pating in a students' protest following the murder of an AMU student. This time, however, he has earned the distinction of being the 148th student to be suspended by Azis.

The university authorities have branded this as "an instance of indiscipline". Public Relations Officer Rahat Abrar puts it succinctly: "Hossain created trouble at the slightest provocation and disrupted peace." Hossain continues to put up a brave front as he jokes, "I think I am the first

local intelligence sleuths indicate what many refer to as a 'madarsa mentality' being imposed gradually in the campus. The last protest inside the campus was staged in 2009 following the death of Shahnawaz Alam, 21, who was shot near a restaurant at the railway station.

Hossain isn't alone in facing the music for his rebellious ways. Twenty-five-year-old Afaq Ahmad who was pursuing an M.Phil in mass communication also met with a similar fate

literature, was asked to shift out of a hostel because she dared to ask some questions to the vc during his visit there. Her expulsion, was revoked later. Officials had earlier admitted that LIU submitted a report to the authority against seven students since they had ideological issues and were creating a 'lot of chaos in the campus'.

The authorities are not in denial either. In a response to another RTI query, the proctor's office admits, "Even peaceful democratic protests like signature campaigns are seen as pressure tactics by the university authorities and hence considered a punishable offence." It also accepted that "pasting of newspaper reports or posters on the walls of the hall and other premises of AMU would also be dealt with harshly". Ironically, the



“ I THINK I AM THE FIRST STUDENT IN THE COUNTRY TO BE PUNISHED FOR USING THE INTERNET TO EXPRESS DISSENT AND EXERCISING MY DEMOCRATIC RIGHTS TO RAISE MY VOICE AGAINST INJUSTICE. ” ADIL HOSSAIN, *Suspended Student, AMU*

No, He Can't? Vice-chancellor Azis wants AMU clones across the nation. But that's easier said than done.

— For The vc dreams of five AMU centres, from Kishanganj in Bihar to Malapuram in Kerala. He says the President approved two of the proposed centres under Section 12(2) of the AMU Act 1981, and that land has been allotted in Bihar.

— Against It destroys AMU's residential nature. Section 5(9A) of the AMU Act prohibits the establishment of special centres more than 25 km from the campus mosque, says M. Shahid, former secretary of AMU Teachers' Association.

— For Azis' office says the University Court, Executive Council and Academic Council have okayed five centres, including three at Bhopal, Murshidabad and Pune; a Rs 2,000-crore proposal has been sent to the HRD Ministry.

— Against Critics say Azis is destroying the AMU by selling it as a brand. Some argue that since the case for restoration of AMU's minority character is pending before the Supreme Court, establishing other AMUs or centres will be illegal.

“ WHAT HOSSAIN DID AMOUNTS TO GROSS INDISCIPLINE. HE CREATED TROUBLE AT THE SLIGHTEST PROVOCATION AND DISRUPTED PEACE ON CAMPUS. HE WAS SUSPENDED LAST YEAR AS WELL FOR INDISCIPLINE. ” RAHAT ABRAR, *PRO, AMU*



student in India to be punished for using the Internet to express dissent." The views are supported by Tariq Islam, an RTI activist and philosophy lecturer at the university. He says the incident has once again established the fact that AMU is nothing but an island that exists in the dark ages. Siras' case and Hossain's suspension preceded by the vc's decision to have as many as 57 CCTV cameras at the cost of Rs 10 crore and the deployment of

when the vc suspended him on April 22 this year for shooting a documentary on his experience with the dining hall system inside the premises. When Hossain filed an RTI application for the same, the provost admitted, "There is no rule, ordinance or regulation that prohibits making a video clip in the hall without the permission of the provost."

Last year, Samia Parveen, 23, a post-graduate student of English

students point out that there is no board across the university where they can put up posters or newspaper clippings and the one at the entrance of Maulana Azad Library has also been removed. The only consolation of a space offered by the varsity is the board where office notifications are put up. "Where is the place for dissent? Should we become suicide bombers to register our protest? This administration is no different from the Nazi regime," says Hossain.

The dissolution of the students' union in 2007 has also rendered them voiceless. "Is this silence the fate of this reputed university?" asks Hossain rhetorically. With authorities not letting one agree to disagree, freedom of expression is perhaps an idea whose time is yet to come at the university. ■